

GUERRILLA WARFARE

SECOND BOER WAR

In October 1899 the independent Boer republics of the Transvaal and the Orange Free State launched a pre-emptive attack on British-ruled South Africa. The conflict later became a guerrilla war, in which lightly armed, mounted Boer commandos defied the military might of the British Empire.

The Boer forces were a citizen militia. Every adult male was issued with a rifle by the central government and was obliged to turn up for military service when called upon, bringing his weapon, ammunition, and a horse. The basic military unit was known as a "commando" – before the term took on its current meaning. The Boers' equipment was light but of high quality. They had the latest Mauser rifles and some state-of-the-art field artillery from the Krupp and Creusot factories in Europe. British infantry were equipped with Lee-Metford and Lee-Enfield rifles, and both sides made use of the machine-gun.

The advent of smokeless powder meant that rifles had become more accurate with better range, an advance which played to a Boer strength: they were excellent sharpshooters, skilled in exploiting cover, especially now that positions were no longer given away by gun smoke. They were also experienced in surviving on the South African veld. But the commandos had their weaknesses: officers were elected, which, though democratic, did not encourage strict discipline. Also most Boers were reluctant to fight far from their home areas, which limited offensive operations.

The Boer army had a series of initial successes, but then suffered repeated defeats as the British counterattacked in strength. In the summer of 1900 British troops occupied the Boer republics and declared the war won, but while some Boers accepted this outcome many did not. Battle-hardened Boer commanders such as Louis Botha, Koos de la Rey, and Christiaan de Wet decided to fight on. They launched a coordinated campaign of guerrilla warfare that caught the British occupying forces utterly

unprepared. Able to move swiftly across the veld and resupply with the local Boer population, the mounted commandos struck at will against railway lines and telegraph wires, supply convoys, and isolated garrisons. Though hugely outnumbered by the British troops, the commandos' hit-and-run attacks denied Britain the chance to bring its superior forces into play. When Boer horsemen did enter into combat against British troops they were usually the victors, exploiting their speed of manoeuvre and superior knowledge of the terrain.

A SCORCHED EARTH POLICY

The British commander-in-chief, Lord Kitchener, responded with a ruthless counterinsurgency campaign. He built a chain of fortified blockhouses linked by barbed wire to protect the railways, before fencing in whole areas of the veld, which could then be swept to flush out the guerrillas. Large numbers of mounted troops were deployed in roaming columns to hunt the commandos. Most controversially, Boer farms, livestock, and crops were also destroyed to deny the guerrillas sustenance, and Boer women and children were herded into British "concentration camps", where thousands died of malnutrition and disease. Thus a pattern was established that was to recur throughout the 20th century – a major power drawn into deploying large-scale forces against an elusive enemy, and in the process politically discrediting its own cause.

In the end the commandos were not defeated, but their leaders recognized that the damage suffered by their own people was too great to be allowed to continue. The British were also eager to end the fighting and a compromise peace was agreed in May 1902.

